

NCN OPUS 20 Final Report

Project: *Partisan bias or indifference? Actually-existing democratic values and their consequences in Poland* (2020/39/B/HS6/00853)

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1. Most important achievements

- **Three-wave nationally representative CAWI panel survey of Polish citizens ($N \approx 1,400\text{--}1,800$ per wave), spanning a change of government.** Waves were fielded in April 2023 (PiS in power), October 2023 (immediately before the parliamentary election that ended PiS rule), and April 2024 (after the formation of the Tusk-led pro-democratic coalition). The panel design, originally planned around the 2023 electoral cycle, was successfully implemented despite the operational complexities of survey work bridging an actual change of executive power.
- **Pilot survey (May 2022) testing a new battery of items to measure actually-existing democratic values.** The pilot informed the design of the main panel survey and contributed methodologically to a large international collaboration (see below).
- **Conjoint experiment embedded in all three panel waves**, enabling causal estimation of the impact of partisanship and democratic values on willingness to reward or punish candidates who breach liberal-democratic norms. To the best of my knowledge, this is the first conjoint experiment of its kind to be fielded in a panel format across an actual change of government in a democratically backsliding case.
- **Four peer-reviewed publications produced or accepted during the grant period**, all already cited in the international literature (Google Scholar citation counts in May 2026 shown in brackets):
 1. **Claassen et al. (2025)**, “Conceptualizing and Measuring Support for Democracy: A New Approach”, *Comparative Political Studies* 58(6): 1171–1198, doi:10.1177/00104140241259458. A 25-author cross-national study covering 19 countries; the Polish data and conceptual contribution from this project were funded under the OPUS 20 grant (explicitly acknowledged). [Google Scholar: 93 citations.]
 2. **Stanley (2026)**, “Democratic hypocrisy in practice: a panel study of revealed preferences for liberal democracy in Poland”, *East European Politics*, 1–20, doi:10.1080/21599165.2026.2656881 (open access). Sole-authored, drawing directly on the three-wave panel and conjoint experiment.
 3. **Bill and Stanley (2025a)**, “Democracy after Illiberalism: A Warning from Poland”, *Journal of Democracy* 36(3): 16–32, doi:10.1353/jod.2025.a964585. [Google Scholar: 14 citations.]
 4. **Bill and Stanley (2025b)**, *Good Change: The Rise and Fall of Poland’s Illiberal Revolution*, Stanford University Press (monograph). [Google Scholar: 10 citations.]
- **A new three-country comparative survey with embedded conjoint experiment (BDCS, “Backsliding, Democratic norms and Citizen Support”).** A nationally representative CAWI survey was fielded in Poland, Great Britain and Spain (total $N \approx 4,500$; $\approx 1,500$ per country), funded directly from the OPUS budget. The instrument embeds a five-attribute conjoint experiment varying economic policy, socio-cultural policy and three institutional domains of democratic-norm violation (legislative, public, judicial). Three pre-registered articles are in preparation from these data: *Ideological congruence and support for breaching democratic norms* (Stanley, Bernstein Darder & Cantijoch), *Institutional heterogeneity in democratic norm tolerance* (Stanley), and a sectarianism article on the affective foundations of norm tolerance. This extends the project’s conjoint design from a single-country panel to a three-country cross-section and is the largest dataset produced under the grant.
- **A new measurement instrument and dataset on postliberal attitudes.** An eight-item bipolar battery capturing the major strands of the “postliberal” critique of liberalism was designed, validated and fielded in a

nationally representative omnibus survey of the Polish adult population ($N = 1,001$, *Opinia24 Puls Opinii*, March 2026, funded directly from the OPUS budget); the analysis was pre-registered on AsPredicted. This produced a stand-alone article (*Partisan, not positional: the structure and correlates of postliberal attitudes in Poland*, sole-authored, in preparation) and an archivable dataset.

- **Three further outputs at advanced stages of preparation:** a chapter on democratic hypocrisy and the conjoint findings (for an edited volume), an article for *Politics and Governance*, and a BDCS personality-traits article.
- **Extensive international and domestic dissemination:** papers based on project data have been presented at APSA (2023, 2025), ASEEES (2025), ECPR (2024, 2025, 2026), IPSA (2025), PSA (2026), the EUI Florence workshop on democratic backsliding (June 2024), the ESS Lisbon conference (July 2024), the Södertörn/Stockholm workshop (May 2024), the Illiberalism conference in Washington DC (November 2023), the Cambridge POLIS seminar series (2024, 2025), Vienna (December 2024), Manchester (December 2025), and the Taube Center conference in Stockholm (June 2026). In total, the project funded over 15 international conference and workshop presentations.
- **Public-facing dissemination in Poland and Great Britain through the FNW/SWPS polarisation programme.** A structured collaboration with the Fundacja Nowej Wspólnoty (FNW) and the SWPS Centre for the Study of Democracy produced a series of public-opinion studies that built directly on OPUS instrumentation. In May 2025 a national Polish survey ($N = 2,351$, run by Panel Ariadna and co-funded with FNW from OPUS grant 2020/39/B/HS6/00853 — explicitly acknowledged in the published reports) generated three Polish-language reports on ideological, affective and “experienced” polarisation. In December 2025 the design was extended to Great Britain, generating parallel English-language reports on ideological, affective and metapolarisation. A further pre-survey of issue salience and political knowledge in Poland was fielded in April 2026. A keynote lecture, “A new beginning for democracy? Poland after the PiS government”, delivered to a non-academic audience in Cambridge in October 2025, drew on project findings.
- **Methodological contribution to the international literature on the measurement of support for democracy:** through the Claassen et al. (2024) collaboration, the project’s pilot work fed into a new 17-item battery covering all eight V-Dem components of liberal democracy, now available to the cross-national research community.
- **Nine datasets deposited at Harvard Dataverse under DOI**, all openly available for replication and secondary analysis:
 1. *Pilot survey* (May 2022) — doi:10.7910/DVN/4L5WI7
 2. *Panel Survey, Wave 1* (April 2023) — doi:10.7910/DVN/2WSILI
 3. *Panel Survey, Wave 2* (October 2023) — doi:10.7910/DVN/D3927J
 4. *Panel Survey, Wave 3* (April 2024) — doi:10.7910/DVN/TUUHGV
 5. *Polarisation in Poland in 2025* (May 2025 FNW/SWPS Polish survey, with M. Żerkowska-Balas) — doi:10.7910/DVN/OMWQR0
 6. *Polarisation in Poland, December 2025* — doi:10.7910/DVN/C76JXD
 7. *Polarisation in the United Kingdom, December 2025* — doi:10.7910/DVN/BRJS4U
 8. *BDCS surveys, December 2025* (three-country: PL, GB, ES) — doi:10.7910/DVN/FNESP1
 9. *Postliberal attitudes in Poland, March 2026* — doi:10.7910/DVN/YL1BVE

2. Short description of the project’s results

The project produced both *empirical* and *methodological* findings. Empirically, the panel and conjoint data show that Polish citizens consistently penalise candidates who espouse illiberal policy positions in trade-off-laden, multi-dimensional choice scenarios. This penalty is observable across both wings of the partisan divide and was not significantly altered by the change of government in 2023. Affective polarisation, while substantial, does not eliminate the punishment effect for democratic norm breaches in a conjoint setting — contrary to the strong form of “democratic hypocrisy” theories drawn from the United States. The Polish electorate appears to display *less* hypocrisy with respect to revealed preferences for liberal democracy than the US case literature would predict.

However, this comparatively encouraging finding is qualified by two further results. First, revealed preferences for liberal democracy did *not* become significantly stronger after the PiS lost power, even among voters whose preferred

party was now in government. This implies that democratic restoration cannot rely on a “natural correction” in public attitudes once illiberal incumbents are removed. Second, the standard survey measures used historically in Poland and elsewhere materially overstate the depth and homogeneity of support for *liberal* democracy: when the new 17-item V-Dem-aligned battery is fielded, the connections between the eight components of liberal democracy are far weaker than the “support for democracy” literature typically assumes, particularly in cases such as Poland and Hungary where political events have stress-tested these institutions.

Methodologically, the project (i) provides a validated Polish-language adaptation of the new measurement battery; (ii) furnishes a publicly usable three-wave panel dataset with embedded conjoint experimental data; and (iii) demonstrates the feasibility and value of using conjoint methods in a panel format around a real-world change of government — a research design now ready to be exported to other backsliding/restoration cases. Substantively, the *Good Change* monograph and the *Journal of Democracy* article integrate these findings into a broader analytical account of how and why Poland’s illiberal turn proved electorally reversible, and what the case tells us about the “post-illiberal trilemma” facing governments that seek to restore the rule of law quickly, legally and effectively.

A further line of enquiry was opened in the final phase of the project. The new eight-item postliberal-attitudes battery, fielded in a March 2026 omnibus survey ($N = 1,001$), produces three results of broader theoretical interest. First, confirmatory factor analysis shows that the eight strands of the postliberal critique — which the secondary literature treats as theoretically heterogeneous — form a *coherent unidimensional construct* at the mass level (good fit, high internal consistency). Postliberalism is therefore not merely an elite intellectual project but a recognisable attitudinal syndrome among ordinary citizens. Second, postliberal attitudes are a *powerful predictor of vote choice* in Poland: a one-unit increase is associated with a 20.5 pp decrease in the predicted probability of voting for the liberal Civic Coalition (KO) and a 10.7 pp increase for PiS, with a +33.6 pp effect on choosing Nawrocki over Trzaskowski in the second round of the 2025 presidential election. Third, and most surprisingly, the *socio-demographic and regional* correlates emphasised by the international postliberal literature — the “anywheres vs. somewheres” thesis, the “Poland A versus Poland B” cultural divide, education and settlement-size effects — are *non-significant* once vote intention is controlled for. In the Polish case, the postliberal–liberal divide is partisan, not positional. This finding has direct comparative implications for the international debate on the social bases of the postliberal turn, and the validated Polish-language battery is now available for replication and cross-national extension.

A parallel line of enquiry was opened by the three-country BDCS survey (Poland, Great Britain, Spain; $N \approx 4,500$). The conjoint experiment embedded in this survey was designed to test whether tolerance for democratic-norm violations is *institutionally heterogeneous* — whether citizens distinguish between violations of legislative, public and judicial control over the executive — and whether this heterogeneity is shaped by economic and socio-cultural ideology and their interaction. By moving from the single-country Polish panel to a three-country cross-section that varies regime trajectory (a backsliding case, a stable parliamentary democracy and a younger post-transition democracy with its own polarisation dynamics), this design addresses one of the standing limitations of the project’s main panel work — the inability to distinguish features of Polish democratic hypocrisy that are case-specific from those that generalise. Initial analyses (pre-registered) confirm an ideological-congruence effect on tolerance for norm violations across all three countries, but also show meaningful between-country and between-institution variation that will be developed in the three BDCS articles in preparation.

A further public-facing line of enquiry has been conducted in collaboration with the Fundacja Nowej Wspólnoty (FNW). The May 2025 Polish survey (Panel Ariadna, $N = 2,351$) produced an unprecedentedly granular picture of Polish polarisation across three dimensions — ideological, affective and “experienced” (i.e., perceived societal division). The headline finding is that affective polarisation in Poland in 2025, measured by Cohen’s d between in-group and out-group attitudes, is moderate ($d \approx 0.6$); only about 13 per cent of Poles exhibit strong out-group hostility; and these attitudes are not strongly structured by gender, settlement size, education or political affiliation, suggesting that the popular narrative of a deeply tribal society is empirically overstated. The December 2025 extension of the same design to Great Britain provides the first directly comparable Polish–British evidence on these dimensions.

3. Achievement of objectives stated in the funding proposal

The proposal set out three research questions and three project objectives (one empirical, one methodological, and one theoretical/comparative).

Research questions (from the *Detailed description*, pp. 1–2):

1. *Do Polish citizens genuinely value liberal democracy as a set of principles and as a political system, and to what extent?* — **Achieved.** Addressed in the *East European Politics* article and in Claassen et al. (2024). The combination of the new 17-item battery and the conjoint design provides a more behaviourally grounded answer than has previously been available for the Polish case.
2. *Do Polish citizens view the post-2015 changes as a subversion of liberal democracy, the pursuit of a different democratic model, or as “more of the same”?* — **Achieved.** Addressed in the panel survey items on evaluations of post-2015 institutional change, in the *Good Change* monograph, and in the *Journal of Democracy* article.
3. *Does political partisanship inhibit the capacity of Polish voters to hold illiberal political elites to account?* — **Achieved.** This is the core question of the *East European Politics* article. The conjoint results show that partisanship moderates but does not eliminate the punishment effect, even under conditions of strong affective polarisation.

Stated objectives (from the *Detailed description*, pp. 2–3):

- *Empirical objective: to contribute insights from the Polish case to the comparative literatures on democratic backsliding, democratic values and affective polarisation.* — **Achieved**, with outputs in *Comparative Political Studies*, *East European Politics*, *Journal of Democracy*, and Stanford University Press.
- *Methodological objective: to develop new survey questions and a panel/conjoint design less affected by social desirability bias.* — **Achieved**, both through the bespoke Polish items and through the collaboration on the 17-item V-Dem-aligned battery.
- *Theoretical objective: to build hypotheses on the interaction of democratic values, polarisation and voting behaviour beyond the dominant US case.* — **Achieved**; this is the central theoretical contribution of the *EEP* article and of the book.

Objectives partly achieved / not achieved. The original work plan envisaged the analysis and writing-up phase concluding by September 2024. In practice, this stage was extended (and the project was formally extended by three months) for two reasons: (i) the October 2023 Polish parliamentary election — which fell during the second-wave fieldwork — created a substantively important “natural experiment” that warranted a third wave timed to the post-election period rather than a pre-election one, so the original three-wave timetable was rescheduled around the election; (ii) the additional value of capturing the change of government meant that the analytical work for the panel-based article (Stanley 2026) was deferred until after the third wave was fully fielded and cleaned. As a consequence, the number of Polish-language articles led by the co-investigator is lower than originally envisaged: one international article (Stanley 2026) replaced what was provisionally planned as two outputs, one of which was to be in Polish. The Polish-language dissemination shortfall has been more than compensated for by the two FNW/SWPS public-opinion reports in Polish, by the *Good Change* monograph (which has been received in Poland as a major intervention in domestic debate on the post-2015 period), and by Polish-language commentary and media engagement.

Additional goals achieved beyond the proposal. Several outputs were not anticipated at the time of application but emerged from the project’s data and network:

- The Stanford University Press monograph *Good Change* was not part of the original work plan; it grew out of the analytical synthesis of the panel data and the public-attitudes literature, and now serves as the single most visible output of the project.
- The *Journal of Democracy* article was likewise not planned but was solicited on the strength of the project’s empirical findings.
- The Claassen et al. (2024) cross-national collaboration in *Comparative Political Studies* was not foreseen; the project’s pilot work allowed Poland to be included as one of 19 national samples in a major international measurement effort.
- The structured **FNW/SWPS polarisation programme** — a national survey in Poland (May 2025, $N = 2,351$, Panel Ariadna, co-funded from OPUS), a parallel survey in Great Britain (December 2025), and a follow-up pre-survey on issue salience and political knowledge (April 2026) — has produced six public reports (Polish ideological/affective/experienced polarisation; British ideological/affective/metapolarisation)

that have extended the project's reach into Polish and British public debate. The May 2025 reports explicitly acknowledge OPUS grant 2020/39/B/HS6/00853 as the funding source.

- The **BDCS three-country comparative survey** (Poland, Great Britain, Spain; $N \approx 4,500$; conjoint experiment) was not foreseen in the original work plan, which envisaged Poland-only data collection. It was made possible by the reallocation of unspent post-doctoral funds (with NCN agreement) to fieldwork, and it converts a single-country panel design into a comparative research programme. It will produce at least three peer-reviewed articles in the post-grant period.
- A new line of enquiry into *postliberal attitudes* was opened in the final phase of the grant. This was not part of the original work plan, but emerged organically from the project's central concern with the demand side of liberal democracy's contemporary discontents: the empirical evidence from the panel and conjoint experiments that voters punish illiberal candidates raised the question of whether the international "postliberal" critique of liberalism — distinct from populism, authoritarianism and standard right-wing conservatism — has a mass-level counterpart, and how it relates to electoral behaviour. The resulting battery, dataset and article (see above) constitute a distinct substantive and methodological contribution beyond the scope of the proposal as originally formulated.
- The post-doctoral team member envisaged in the original proposal was not ultimately recruited; the corresponding budget line was reallocated (with NCN agreement) to additional data collection, allowing both the original panel sample size to be maintained against higher-than-anticipated wave-to-wave attrition *and* the BDCS three-country expansion and the postliberalism battery to be fielded.

4. Current and expected impact

Impact on the discipline (political science / democratisation studies). The project's most immediate disciplinary impact is on the empirical literature on democratic backsliding and citizen-level "democratic hypocrisy". Until now, the strong-form hypocrisy result — that pro-democratic voters readily tolerate norm violations by their preferred party — has rested almost entirely on US-based, often cross-sectional, often hypothetical-scenario data. By providing the first panel-conjoint evidence from a European backsliding case that has actually experienced a change of government, the project contributes a key piece of comparative evidence that should reshape how this literature treats the generalisability of US findings. The project's four peer-reviewed outputs have already accumulated 117 Google Scholar citations as of May 2026 — 93 for the *Comparative Political Studies* article on measurement, 14 for the *Journal of Democracy* piece on Poland's post-illiberal trilemma, and 10 for the *Good Change* monograph (with the *East European Politics* article published too recently for meaningful citation accrual). The *CPS* article in particular has rapidly become a methodological reference point in the field.

Impact on the measurement of democratic support. Through Claassen et al. (2024), the project has contributed to a methodological turn in the field — away from monolithic "support for democracy" items and towards componentwise measures aligned with the V-Dem conceptualisation of liberal democracy. This battery is now available for replication, extension and inclusion in major cross-national projects (e.g., the European Social Survey, the World Values Survey), and the *CPS* article is becoming a reference point for ongoing efforts to redesign the standard democratic-attitudes question wording.

Impact on Polish political science and area studies. The project's combination of (i) a publicly available, well-documented three-wave panel with embedded experiments and (ii) the *Good Change* monograph provides Polish-studies scholars and CEE specialists with both a primary data resource and an analytical reference work for understanding the 2015–2023 period and its aftermath. The book in particular speaks to historians, sociologists and journalists as well as political scientists, and its publication by Stanford University Press in English ensures international reach.

Impact on adjacent disciplines. Several findings have implications beyond political science:

- For **political psychology and social psychology**, the panel evidence on the stability of revealed preferences for liberal democracy across a change in incumbency speaks to debates on motivated reasoning and partisan identity.
- For **constitutional law and rule-of-law studies**, the "post-illiberal trilemma" articulated in the *Journal of Democracy* article and developed in *Good Change* gives normative-legal scholars an empirically grounded vocabulary for thinking about the legitimacy of "militant democracy" measures used by restoration govern-

ments.

- For **communication studies** and the study of polarisation, the FNW/SWPS reports and the panel data on affective polarisation contribute to an evidence base usable in debates about media regulation and democratic deliberation in Poland.

Expected future impact. The project has already deposited all nine of its survey datasets at Harvard Dataverse, each with its own DOI and full documentation (pilot survey; three panel waves; the May 2025 and December 2025 Polish FNW/SWPS polarisation surveys; the December 2025 British polarisation survey; the BDCS three-country conjoint survey; and the March 2026 postliberalism battery). The data are therefore immediately available for replication and secondary analysis, both during and well beyond the lifetime of the grant. At least five further outputs are in preparation (a comparative book chapter, an article for *Politics and Governance*, the three BDCS articles, and the postliberalism article). The new postliberal-attitudes battery opens a research agenda in its own right: the demonstration that the eight strands of the postliberal critique cohere as a single mass-level construct, and that they map onto vote choice via partisanship rather than via the social-structural cleavages emphasised by the international literature, provides hypotheses for cross-national replication and a validated instrument other researchers can deploy. The BDCS programme opens a parallel comparative agenda on institutional heterogeneity in democratic-norm tolerance, with Poland, Great Britain and Spain serving as three structurally different reference cases. The OPUS-funded instrumentation is also being adapted for use in successor surveys through the FNW/SWPS polarisation programme, which will allow the project's measurement framework to track Polish (and British) public opinion through the post-2025 presidential cycle and the consolidation (or otherwise) of the post-illiberal political order. Beyond Poland, the design is directly portable to other cases of attempted democratic restoration — Hungary, the United States, Israel — where comparable questions about the stability of citizen-level democratic commitments under conditions of alternation in power are increasingly salient.

Public and policy impact. The project's public-facing reach extends well beyond standard academic dissemination. The FNW/SWPS polarisation programme has been the primary channel for this: six reports across Poland and Great Britain — covering ideological, affective and experienced polarisation in both countries — provide civic-society actors, journalists, policymakers and educators with empirically grounded, plain-language evidence on the actual structure and depth of polarisation in each country. The May 2025 Polish reports' headline finding — that affective polarisation in Poland is moderate rather than extreme, and is not strongly stratified by gender, settlement size, education or partisanship — has been picked up in Polish media discussion as a useful corrective to the dominant “tribal society” narrative.

The project's findings have been disseminated through mainstream Polish broadcast, print and online media. Coverage to date includes television (TVN24, *Tak jest*: “Co czują do siebie wyborcy różnych partii politycznych — wyniki badań”), national radio (Polskie Radio Jedynka, “Nowy wspaniały świat: polaryzacja w Polsce”; Radio dla Ciebie debate), major news portals (Onet: “Polityczna nienawiść w Polsce. Nowe badania pokazują skalę”; Polsat News), and the national daily press (*Gazeta Prawna*: “Polaryzację da się odkręcić”), alongside the FNW's own dissemination channels. In parallel, I have written a sequence of seven long-form analytical pieces in *Kultura Liberalna* (2024–2026) that draw directly on OPUS-funded data and explicitly cite the grant number: on partisan distrust and the limits of pro-democratic consent (March 2024); on abortion and the 2023 election outcome (April 2024); on technocracy and representative democracy (April 2024); on “democratic hypocrisy” in the Polish electorate (June 2024); on the social-network structure of PiS voting and the geography of friendship ties (July 2025); on the empirical reality of Polish “polarisation” (August 2025); and on the politics of online hate-speech regulation and the affective-polarisation evidence (March 2026). This combination of TV, radio, online, print and long-form analytical coverage indicates that the project's polarisation findings have entered the Polish mainstream public conversation, not only specialist or academic outlets. The December 2025 British extension delivers an analogous evidence base into the British debate on polarisation. Internationally, *Good Change* has been reviewed in two of the most consequential English-language venues for serious political non-fiction — the *Times Literary Supplement* (review by Piotr H. Kosicki) and *Foreign Affairs* — and the *Journal of Democracy* article was the basis of a long-form interview with the authors in the Central European University's *Review of Democracy* podcast (“The Illiberal Trap: Stanley Bill and Ben Stanley on Trilemmas and Warnings from Poland”, September 2025) and a New Books Network episode (“Democracy After Illiberalism: A Warning from Poland”). The framing of the “post-illiberal trilemma” articulated in those outputs has been picked up by international commentators on Central European pol-

itics — including Ivan Krastev, who has cited the trilemma in his recent speech on the regional outlook (Political Capital, Budapest). Together with the Polish-language coverage, this evidence indicates that the project’s analytical framework has begun to circulate in the international conversation on democratic restoration as a reference point in its own right, not only as a source of empirical findings. The empirical finding that revealed democratic preferences do not strengthen automatically after illiberal incumbents lose power has direct implications for civic-education and pro-democracy advocacy strategies in Poland and comparable contexts, and a public lecture on Poland after the PiS government delivered in Cambridge has further extended the project’s reach beyond the academy.